

Overcalls

Because of the Defensive element, the most important requirement for an Overcall is that you have a good suit, one that you'd like partner to lead. Keep in mind:

- a 5-card or longer suit with honor strength

- 9-16 points to overcall at the 1-level

- 11-16 points to overcall at the 2-level

Takeout Doubles

There are three kinds of Takeout Double:

- opening hand strength, no more than 2 of opponent's suit, at least 3 in all other suits
- strong Overcall type, at least 17 points and a good suit. Double, then bid the suit.
- strong Notrump type, 19+ points, stopper in their suit. Double, then bid notrump.

Responding to a Takeout Double

- 0-8 points, bid your best suit as cheaply as possible

- 9-11 points, jump in your best suit

- 12 or more points, cue-bid the opponent's suit

Board: 1
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 1 ♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦ Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 4 ♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥ K

Board: 3
Dealer: **East**
Contract: 3 ♠
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥ A

Board: 4
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 4 ♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦ 4

Board: 5
Dealer: **East**
Contract: 2 ♣
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥ K

Board 1

West Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 8
♥ A 6 4 3
♦ 8 5 4 3
♣ A K J

♠ A K J 7 4

♥ 8 7

♦ A 7 6

♣ Q 5 4



♠ 5 3

♥ K Q J 10

♦ Q J 10 2

♣ 10 7 3

♠ Q 9 6 2

♥ 9 5 2

♦ K 9

♣ 9 8 6 2

NORTH has an opening hand, 15 points, and a 5-card ♠ suit. Unfortunately WEST beat her to the punch by opening 1♥.

But NORTH should get into the bidding anyway, by Overcalling 1♠. This shows a good ♠ suit and somewhere between 9 and 16 points.

SOUTH has 6 points. If NORTH had actually OPENED 1♠, SOUTH would be obligated to bid. But knowing that the Overcall will not be made with more than 16 points, SOUTH just passes.

West

1♥

North

1♠

*East**South*

All Pass

1♠ by North

Lead: ♦Q

Board 2

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q 9 6 2

♥ 10 5 2

♦ K Q 4

♣ K J 6

♠ 5 3

♥ Q 6 4 3

♦ 10 5 3 2

♣ A 10 9

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A K J 7 4

♥ 8 7

♦ A 7 6

♣ Q 5 4

♠ 10 8

♥ A K J 9

♦ J 9 8

♣ 8 7 3 2

*West**North**East**South*

1 ♥

1 ♠

Pass

2 ♠

Pass

4 ♠

All Pass

4 ♠ by East

Lead: ♥K

EAST has an opening hand, 15 points and five ♠s. But NORTH beat him to the punch, so he overcalls 1 ♠.

WEST has 11 points, and if EAST had opened she would make a Limit Raise to 3 ♠.

But when replying to an Overcall, the strength needs to be a little higher. In Deal 1 it was OK to pass a 1 ♠ Overcall with 6 points, here it is correct to just raise to 2 ♠ with 11 points.

EAST actually has a strong Overcall so he bids 4 ♠.

Board 3

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ 5 3
 ♥ A K J 3
 ♦ Q 10 3 2
 ♣ A 9 3

♠ Q 9 6 2

♥ 10 5 2

♦ A K

♣ K 8 6 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 10 8

♥ Q 9 6 4

♦ J 8 5 4

♣ Q 10 7

♠ A K J 7 4

♥ 8 7

♦ 9 7 6

♣ J 5 4

*West**North**East**South*

1♥

1♠

Pass

3♠

All Pass

3♠ by South

Lead: ♥A

This time SOUTH has just 10 points, nowhere near an opening hand. Still, when EAST opens 1♥ SOUTH should Overcall 1♠. This shows a good ♠ suit and somewhere between 9 and 16 points.

NORTH has 13 points. If SOUTH had actually OPENED 1♠, NORTH would insist on game. But SOUTH didn't Open, she just Overcalled. So NORTH must be more cautious. He jumps to 3♠ and SOUTH shows her minimum type hand by passing.

Board 4

North Deals

Both Vul

♠ A 10 5 3
♥ 10 7 5
♦ Q 8
♣ A 8 6 2

♠ 7 4 2

♥ Q 9 8 2

♦ 9 6 4 2

♣ J 10



♠ K 9 8 6

♥ 4

♦ A K 7 3

♣ K Q 7 5

♠ Q J

♥ A K J 6 3

♦ J 10 5

♣ 9 4 3

EAST has 15 points, a singleton in the opponent's suit and 4-card support for any suit partner might name. In other words, a perfect Takeout Double.

WEST needs to make a medium-strong bid to apprise EAST of her 10 points. She jumps to 2♠.

EAST's hand is now worth 17 points because of the singleton. Since he is quite happy with ♠s he bids 4♠.

*West**North**East**South*

2♠

1♥

Dbl

Pass

Pass

4♠

All Pass

4♠ by West

Lead: ♦4

Board 5

East Deals

N-S Vul

♠ A K J 9

♥ 10 9 8

♦ A 10 3

♣ Q 10 5

♠ 7 6 4 2

♥ 7 6 3

♦ 8 6 4

♣ J 9 8



♠ Q 10 8

♥ K Q 5

♦ 9 7 5 2

♣ A 6 3

♠ 5 3

♥ A J 4 2

♦ K Q J

♣ K 7 4 2

*West**North**East**South*

Pass

2♣

All Pass

2♣ by North

Lead: ♥K

1♠

Dbl

SOUTH has 14 points, a doubleton in the opponent's ♠ suit and at least three cards in each of the other suits. This is a normal Takeout Double.

NORTH has a really awful hand. He has just one point and his only 4-card suit is the one the opponents have already bid. He wants nothing more than to pass.

But he cannot pass. Partner's Double said "Bid your best suit.", so he bids 2♣.

Mercifully SOUTH also passes.